The past comes down to us preserved in objects and words. The challenge lies in trying to tease out Ashoka's story by listening to the emperor's own voice even while paying attention to the many stories that emerge in archaeology about the lives and times of his more ordinary contemporaries. By Ashoka's own account, his wide dominions had a large and diverse population, from city residents and members of religious sects to ordinary rural folk, forest dwellers, and fisher people. Archaeology allows us to peep into the places where such ordinary folk lived, to find out what food they ate, to imagine their ideas about rulers and religion, to travel with them as they journeyed forth, and to appreciate the remarkable paintings that they sometimes made on the very waysides where the emperor's voice could be heard.[21] Such sights and subjects will be explored as we try to understand the India of Ashoka's time, above all because such archaeological glimpses offer a reality check on Ashoka's own prescriptions and proscriptions.

Modern India—as indeed modern Sri Lanka, Tibet, Nepal, and Myanmar—continues to be interested in Ashoka as the Buddhist king of later traditions rather than the all-too-human emperor of his own time. Notwithstanding the great deal that has been written about him, I will try to show that a 'biography' of Ashoka cannot really be disentangled from the legends and perceptions, Buddhist hagiography, and the many validations and valorizations of later times surrounding him. This difficulty is not specific to Ashoka; it is precisely the package of problems that scholars grappling with other ancient lives have faced. Biographers of Alexander the Great (*c*. 356–323 BCE) have, for example, drawn attention to the contradictory and non-contemporary character of narrative accounts of his life and career, all of which were composed many hundred years after his death. While such writings relied on a wide range of earlier works, none of those originals have actually survived except in highly fragmentary form, which has resulted in a lack of agreement among modern scholars about